

Placement Test, Pre-A1 to C2

One test for placing adult learners into the right course, from English Foundations (A1) to Mastery English (C2). Learners do a written part (grammar and vocabulary, reading, writing) and have a short one-to-one speaking interview with you. You combine the two results into one recommended course.

Part A 50 multiple choice

Part B 2 reading texts

Part C writing

Part D 5-min interview

About 75 min + interviews

TEACHER PAGES

BEFORE YOU START: THIS IS A PLACEMENT, NOT AN EXAM

Many adult learners have bad memories of tests, and some have had little or no schooling. Say it plainly, with gestures or a shared language if you have one: **"This test is to find the right class for you. You can't pass or fail. Stop when it's too difficult. That's OK."** Nobody should sit for an hour in front of questions they can't read.

ADMINISTERING THE TEST

PART	TIME	WHO	WHAT HAPPENS
Welcome	5 min	T-S	Explain the purpose (see above). Give out the learner pages. Show how to circle an answer, using the example on the board. Learners write their name, or a first name only.
A • Grammar & vocabulary	30 min	S	50 questions, easy to hard. Learners circle a, b, c or d . Tell them not to guess: "If you don't know, leave it empty." Learners may stop early.
B • Reading	20 min	S	Text 1 (A2 level, 5 questions) for everyone who reached Section 2 of Part A. Text 2 (B2 level, 5 questions) only if Text 1 felt easy.
C • Writing	20 min	S	Task 1 (a short form) for everyone. Task 2 if they can. Task 3 if Task 2 was easy.
D • Speaking interview	5 min each	T-S	One to one, in a quiet corner, while the others write. Follow the script below. Pre-literate and low-literacy learners start here (see the literacy note).

◆ YOU NEED

- ◆ One copy of the learner pages (Parts A–C) per learner
- ◆ One copy of the interview script (Part D), with the picture card, for you
- ◆ The answer key and band descriptors ([placement-test-key.html](#))
- ◆ Pencils, and a clock the learners can see

◆ GROUND RULES

- ◆ No dictionaries or phones during Parts A–C.
- ◆ Explain **instructions** in any language that helps; don't explain the **questions**.
- ◆ Let learners stop at any point. Collect their pages with a smile.
- ◆ Personal questions are always optional. A learner may give a "new identity": a made-up name, town or job.

PART A · GRAMMAR AND VOCABULARY

Name _____

Date _____

Class / group _____

 **Circle the best answer: a, b, c or d.** Example: *I ___ a student.* a) am b) is c) are d) be → circle a.

The questions start easy and get harder. **Don't know? Leave it empty.** You can stop when it is too difficult. That is OK.

SECTION 1 · QUESTIONS 1-10

1. Hello! My name ___ Ana.

a) am b) is c) are d) be

3. I want ___ apple, please.

a) a b) an c) two d) these

5. ___ you like coffee?

a) Are b) Do c) Does d) Is

7. There ___ two chairs in the kitchen.

a) is b) are c) be d) has

9. Look! It ___ now.

a) rains b) is raining c) rain d) raining

2. Where ___ you from?

a) is b) am c) are d) do

4. My sister ___ 25 years old.

a) has b) have c) is d) are

6. She ___ in a hospital.

a) work b) works c) working d) is work

8. My mother's brother is my ___.

a) uncle b) aunt c) cousin d) son

10. What time is it? — It's half ___ seven.

a) past b) to c) at d) on

SECTION 2 · QUESTIONS 11-19

11. I ___ to the doctor yesterday.

a) go b) goes c) went d) gone

13. My brother is ___ than me.

a) tall b) taller c) more tall d) tallest

15. Have you ever ___ sushi?

a) eat b) ate c) eaten d) eating

17. She has lived here ___ 2019.

a) for b) since c) ago d) from

19. I need to ___ an appointment with the dentist.

a) do b) make c) take d) have

12. ___ you see the game last night?

a) Do b) Did c) Were d) Are

14. We ___ visit my aunt next weekend.

a) going to b) are going to c) go to d) will to

16. I was cooking dinner when the phone ___.

a) ring b) rang c) was ringing d) rings

18. It's the ___ restaurant in town.

a) better b) goodest c) best d) most good

SECTION 3 • QUESTIONS 20–28

20. If it rains tomorrow, we ____ at home.

- a) stay b) will stay c) would stay d) stayed

22. If I ____ more money, I would buy a car.

- a) have b) had c) will have d) would have

24. He asked me where ____.

- a) did I live b) I lived c) do I live d) lived I

26. The woman ____ lives next door is a nurse.

- a) who b) which c) what d) whose

28. Can you ____ my cat while I'm on vacation?

- a) look after b) look for c) look up d) look out

SECTION 4 • QUESTIONS 29–37

29. By the time we arrived, the movie ____.

- a) already started b) had already started
c) has already started d) was already starting

31. I wish I ____ so much last night. I feel terrible.

- a) didn't eat b) hadn't eaten c) wouldn't eat
d) don't eat

33. He denied ____ the money.

- a) to take b) taking c) take d) that take

35. The new rule had a big ____ on small businesses.

- a) affect b) impact c) result d) cause

37. The meeting has been ____ until next Tuesday.

- a) put off b) put up c) put out d) put through

SECTION 5 • QUESTIONS 38–44

38. Not only ____ late, but he also forgot the tickets.

- a) he was b) was he c) he is d) did he be

21. I ____ English for two years now.

- a) study b) am studying c) have been studying
d) studied

23. This bridge ____ in 1920.

- a) built b) was built c) is building d) has built

25. I used to ____ in the countryside when I was a child.

- a) live b) living c) lived d) lives

27. I'm really looking forward ____ you.

- a) to see b) seeing c) to seeing d) see

30. If I had known about the traffic, I ____ earlier.

- a) would leave b) will leave c) would have left
d) had left

32. She ____ have left already — her coat is still here.

- a) can't b) must c) should d) needn't

34. The report ____ by Friday.

- a) must finish b) must be finished
c) must have finish d) must finishing

36. ____ the rain, the game went ahead.

- a) Although b) Despite c) However d) Even

39. Had I realized how difficult it was, I ____ it.

- a) wouldn't attempt b) wouldn't have attempted
c) hadn't attempted d) won't have attempted

40. It's high time the city ____ something about housing.

- a) does b) did c) will do d) has done

42. The findings, ____ were published last month, have been widely criticized.

- a) that b) which c) what d) who

44. ____ you need any further information, please do not hesitate to contact me.

- a) Should b) Would c) Were d) Unless

SECTION 6 • QUESTIONS 45-50

45. The minister's remarks were widely seen as an attempt to ____ the issue.

- a) sidestep b) sidetrack c) sideline d) sideswipe

47. His apology struck many as ____ — polite, but clearly insincere.

- a) perfunctory b) punctilious c) prodigious
d) precocious

49. The plan, ____, proved unworkable in practice.

- a) sound as it seemed on paper
b) as it seemed sound on paper
c) seeming as sound on paper
d) though it seemed as sound on paper

41. Her argument was so ____ that nobody could find a flaw in it.

- a) cogent b) cordial c) candid d) copious

43. The company is facing ____ criticism over its safety record.

- a) mounting b) climbing c) rising up
d) growing up

46. Scarcely ____ the stage when the lights went out.

- a) she had reached b) had she reached
c) she reached d) did she reached

48. She is by no means the only one ____ for the delay.

- a) to blame b) blaming c) to be blaming
d) blamed

50. I'd sooner you ____ mention this to anyone just yet.

- a) don't b) didn't c) won't d) wouldn't

PART B · READING

 **Text 1.** Read the email. Circle the best answer: a, b or c.

From: Sam · To: Lina · Subject: Next week

Hi Lina,

Thanks for your email. I'm sorry I didn't come to class on Tuesday. My daughter was sick, so I stayed at home with her. She's better now, and she went back to school yesterday.

I have some news! Next week I'm starting a new job at a supermarket near the train station. I'm going to work in the mornings, from 6 a.m. to 12, so I can't come to the morning English class any more. I'm going to change to the evening class on Mondays and Thursdays. Is the evening class bigger than the morning class?

Can we meet for coffee on Saturday? I'm free after 2 o'clock.

See you soon,
Sam

1. Why didn't Sam come to class on Tuesday?
a) He was sick. b) His daughter was sick. c) He started his new job.
2. Where is Sam's new job?
a) At a school. b) At a train station. c) At a supermarket.
3. When is Sam going to work?
a) In the mornings. b) In the evenings. c) On Saturdays.
4. Which days is the evening class?
a) Tuesdays and Thursdays. b) Mondays and Thursdays. c) Mondays and Saturdays.
5. When can Sam meet Lina on Saturday?
a) In the morning. b) Before 2 o'clock. c) After 2 o'clock.

 **Text 2.** Only read this text if Text 1 was easy for you. Read the article and circle the best answer: a, b, c or d.

Could a shorter week make us better workers?

When a group of companies agreed to try a four-day working week for six months, few observers expected the results to be so striking. Employees kept the same salary but worked roughly 20 percent fewer hours, on the condition that they maintained their usual output. By the end of the trial, most of the participating firms reported that productivity had either stayed the same or improved, and the vast majority chose to continue with the new schedule.

Supporters argue that the benefits go beyond the office. Staff in the trial reported sleeping better, feeling less stressed and having more time for their families, and many companies found it easier to recruit and keep good people. Critics, however, point out that the firms taking part were volunteers — organizations that already believed the idea would work — and that a four-day week is far harder to arrange in hospitals, schools or factories, where someone has to be present at all times.

What seems clear is that the traditional five-day week is not a law of nature. It was itself a reform, introduced about a century ago. Whether the next change comes quickly or slowly, the debate is no longer about *whether* working time can change, but *how*.

6. During the trial, employees...
 - a) earned less money for fewer hours.
 - b) worked fewer hours for the same pay.
 - c) worked longer days but only four days a week.
 - d) chose their own hours.
7. At the end of the trial, most companies...
 - a) returned to the five-day week.
 - b) reduced salaries.
 - c) decided to keep the four-day week.
 - d) asked the government for help.
8. What is one criticism mentioned in the text?
 - a) Workers felt more stressed.
 - b) Productivity fell sharply.
 - c) The companies already believed the idea would work.
 - d) Hospitals refused to take part.
9. The word *striking* (paragraph 1) is closest in meaning to...
 - a) violent.
 - b) surprising and impressive.
 - c) disappointing.
 - d) expected.
10. The writer's main point in the last paragraph is that...
 - a) the five-day week will end very soon.
 - b) working time has changed before and can change again.
 - c) the four-day week is a failed experiment.
 - d) governments should make a new law.

PART C · WRITING

 **Task 1 (everyone).** Fill in the form. You can leave a line empty. You can write a different name or town if you prefer.

First name	
Country or city (from)	
Languages I speak	
I want to learn English because...	

 **Task 2 (if you can).** Write about **your day or your week** in 3 to 6 sentences. What do you do? What do you like?

 **Task 3 (if Task 2 was easy).** Write **120–180 words**. Choose **one**:

- ◆ A. Describe a time when you learned something new, at work, at school or in your life. How did you learn it, what was difficult, and what advice would you give to someone learning it now?
- ◆ B. "Everyone should learn a second language." How far do you agree? Give reasons and examples.

PART D · SPEAKING INTERVIEW (5 MINUTES)

Interview one learner at a time. **Start at the A1 band and move up.** Spend about a minute on each band the learner handles comfortably; you won't use every band with every learner. Rephrase once if a question isn't understood.

Stop rule: when the learner can't manage **two prompts in a band**, even after rephrasing, stop there, finish with a friendly closing question they *can* answer, and thank them. Take notes as you go; rate afterwards with the speaking descriptors in the key.

KEEP IT SAFE AND RESPECTFUL

Don't ask why someone left their country, about family members who aren't with them, or about immigration status. If a learner seems uncomfortable with a personal question, move on straight away ("No problem! Next question..."). Every personal prompt below has a neutral alternative in brackets.

PRE-A1 / A1 Simple facts, pictures, numbers ~1-1½ min

SAY: *Hello! My name is _____. What's your name? · How do you spell it?*

SAY: *Where are you from? [or: What languages do you speak?]*

SAY: *(Picture card) What's this? ... And this? · What color is it? · What is he/she doing?*

SAY: *(Number card) Can you read these numbers?*

SAY: *What do you do every day? · Do you like coffee?*

Listen for: single words vs. short sentences · names of common things · numbers · *I'm / I like / I work*. A learner who answers only by pointing, nodding or with single L1 words is **Pre-A1**.

A2 Past, future, everyday descriptions ~1 min

SAY: *What did you do last weekend?*

SAY: *What are you going to do next weekend?*

SAY: *Tell me about your town [or: this town]. Is it big or small? What do you like about it?*

SAY: *What job do you do, or what job would you like to do?*

Listen for: past forms (*went, visited*) · *going to* · linked sentences with *and, but, because* · simple comparisons.

B1 Experiences, opinions, hypotheticals ~1 min

SAY: *Tell me about a time when something went wrong, like a trip or a day at work. What happened, and what did you do?*

SAY: *If you could live anywhere in the world, where would you live? Why?*

SAY: *What advice would you give someone who has just moved to this area?*

Listen for: a connected story with a beginning, middle and end · reasons and simple opinions · *would* · keeping going without long pauses, even with errors.

B2 Arguing a view, pros and cons ~1 min

SAY: *Some people say that smartphones make our lives more stressful. What do you think? Give me some reasons and examples.*

SAY: *What are the advantages and disadvantages of working from home?*

SAY: *How has your town or country [or: the place you know best] changed in recent years? Why do you think that is?*

Listen for: a clear position developed with reasons · balancing two sides (*on the other hand, although*) · few errors that cause misunderstanding · a range of vocabulary beyond everyday words.

C1 Abstract topics, explanation, challenge ~1 min

SAY: Explain something from your work or studies, a process or an idea, as if I knew nothing about it.

SAY: What do you think are the main reasons housing has become so expensive in many cities, and what could realistically be done about it?

SAY: (Push back politely) I'm not sure I agree. Couldn't you argue the opposite?

Listen for: fluent, well-organized explanation · hedging and precise vocabulary · handling a challenge without losing the thread · errors rare and usually self-corrected.

C2 Nuance, register, persuasion ~1 min

SAY: Some would argue that tradition holds societies back. How far would you go along with that?

SAY: What, for you, is the difference between persuading someone and manipulating them?

SAY: Now explain your answer again, but as you would to a twelve-year-old.

Listen for: subtle distinctions and exact word choice · idiomatic, natural phrasing · shifting register at will · effortless flow, with a fully convincing argument.

◆ PICTURE CARD (SHOW THE LEARNER)



apple



bus



coffee



house



doctor



rain



shoes



cooking

7

15

42

100

The small labels are for you. Cover them, or fold the card, when you show it. For the "What is he/she doing?" prompt, point to 🍳 ("He's cooking") or ☔ ("It's raining").

◆ INTERVIEW RECORD

LEARNER	HIGHEST BAND HANDLED COMFORTABLY	NOTES: STRENGTHS, ERRORS, PRONUNCIATION, CONFIDENCE
	Pre-A1 · A1 · A2 · B1 · B2 · C1 · C2	
	Pre-A1 · A1 · A2 · B1 · B2 · C1 · C2	
	Pre-A1 · A1 · A2 · B1 · B2 · C1 · C2	

SCORING AND PLACEMENT

Mark Parts A and B with the key. For each section of Part A, count the correct answers and check whether the learner **secured** it (reached the target). Then choose a course with the two steps below.

PART A SECTION	ITEMS	TARGET (SECURED)	SCORE	SECURED?
Section 1 · A1	1–10	7 / 10		☐
Section 2 · A2	11–19	6 / 9		☐
Section 3 · B1	20–28	6 / 9		☐
Section 4 · B2	29–37	6 / 9		☐
Section 5 · C1	38–44	5 / 7		☐
Section 6 · C2	45–50	4 / 6		☐
Total Part A			/ 50	
Part B · Text 1 (A2)	1–5	4 / 5		☐
Part B · Text 2 (B2)	6–10	4 / 5		☐
Part C · Writing band	see writing descriptors			
Part D · Speaking band	see speaking descriptors			

◆ STEP 1 · THE WRITTEN RESULT

The **written band** is the highest Part A section the learner secured, **with every easier section secured too**. A lucky score in Section 5 doesn't count if Section 3 wasn't secured. Use Part B to confirm: a secured A2 or B2 band should come with Text 1 or Text 2 at 4/5 or better. If the reading disagrees, trust the lower result and look closely at the interview. Then read off the course:

RECOMMENDED COURSE	LEVEL	WRITTEN RESULT
English Foundations	A1 · A1 Beginner	Nothing secured, or Section 1 not yet secured. Includes true beginners and learners with limited literacy.
Everyday English	A2 · A2 Elementary	Section 1 (A1) secured; Section 2 not yet.
Independent English	B1 · B1 Intermediate	Sections 1–2 secured; Section 3 not yet.
Confident English	B2 · B2 Upper-Intermediate	Sections 1–3 secured; Section 4 not yet.

Advanced English	C1 · C1 Advanced	Sections 1–4 secured; Section 5 not yet.
Mastery English	C2 · C2 Proficiency	Sections 1–5 secured (with or without Section 6).

Quick check on the total (Part A): **0–12** Foundations A1 · **13–21** Everyday A2 · **22–30** Independent B1 · **31–38** Confident B2 · **39–45** Advanced C1 · **46–50** Mastery C2. If the total and the section rule disagree, the section rule wins, because totals are pushed up by guessing.

◆ STEP 2 · COMBINE WITH THE SPEAKING BAND

The **speaking band** is the highest band the learner handled comfortably in the interview. Pre-A1 counts as "nothing secured." As with the written result, the recommended course is the **next level up**: a learner comfortable at A2 goes into Independent English (B1).

IF...	THEN...
Written and speaking bands match	Place in the next course up. Done.
They differ by one band	Place by the lower band, note the stronger skill on the learner profile, and do a move-up check after two weeks. At B2 and above you may place by the higher band if the learner's goals are mostly in their stronger skill.
Speaking is two or more bands higher than writing	Usually a literacy or schooling gap, not a language gap. Don't put a fluent speaker in a beginner class. Do the literacy check below, then place one course below the speaking result, with literacy support, or alongside a literacy class.
Writing is two or more bands higher than speaking	Often a learner who studied grammar at school but rarely speaks. Place one course above the speaking result, and flag speaking fluency as their focus.

SPECIALIST COURSES: IELTS ACADEMIC PREPARATION AND BUSINESS ENGLISH

Both are 12-lesson skills courses for learners at about **B1 and above**. Recommend them when a learner's result points to Confident English (B2) or higher and their goal matches: a university or registration band score (IELTS), or work communication (Business). Learners can take them alongside a general course. Below B1, raise the general level first.

DON'T RELY ON THE WRITTEN TEST

A written test measures reading and writing in English *and* familiarity with tests. For a learner who had little schooling, reads slowly in their own language, or uses a non-Latin script (Arabic, Amharic, Chinese, Tigrinya and others), the written score says very little about their English. Some of these learners speak quite a lot of English.

- 1 **Watch the first minute of Part A.** If a learner can't write their name, holds the pencil uncertainly, or looks at the page without starting, quietly collect the paper ("Thank you, let's talk instead") and go straight to the interview. No one should be left to struggle.
- 2 **Use the oral interview and the picture card.** Rate speaking as usual. Many learners reach A1 or A2 in speaking with no reading at all.
- 3 **Do a two-minute literacy check.** Can they: write their first name? copy a short sentence (*I like tea.*)? read a few common signs (**EXIT • OPEN • STOP • BUS • PUSH**)? read numbers and a clock? recognize upper- and lower-case letters? Note what they can and can't do. Don't mark it as a score.
- 4 **Place by speaking, and plan literacy support.** Pre-literate and low-literacy learners at Pre-A1 or A1 speaking go into English Foundations (A1), using the literacy-support strand in each lesson (picture cues, tracing and copying, fewer items). A learner who speaks at A2 or above but reads at a very low level should not start again at A1 for speaking. See Step 2, and if your program has one, combine the class with a literacy class.
- 5 **Record it kindly.** On the learner profile, write what the learner *can* do ("reads numbers, copies words, speaks in short sentences"), not a list of gaps.